

INDIA INC HAS long treated the role of a chief executive officer (CEO) as the pinnacle of professional success, a position associated not just with power and influence, but often identity itself. But what happens after CEOs quit the corner office? Several leaders are now extending their professional life beyond retirement, in a bid to hold on to their sense of self.

In India, where professional identity is deeply tied to designation, visibility, and authority, stepping away from leadership can become psychologically complex. Former CEOs speak of confronting silence after decades of constant momentum, of waking up without packed calendars or urgent decisions waiting for them, and of discovering how deeply their sense of self had become tied to the institutions they led.

For Ravi Venkatesan, former Chairman of Microsoft India and Bank of Baroda, the transition initially felt “difficult, disorienting, and uncomfortable”, a phase he describes as “de-addiction from work”. Vineet Nayar, former CEO of HCL Technologies, recalls confronting a void that many leaders struggle to sit with after corporate life slows down. Ganesh Natarajan, former CEO of Zensar Technologies and Aptech, admits he worried about losing visibility and relevance once the designation disappeared. Kris Gopalakrishnan, co-founder and former Vice Chairman and CEO of Infosys, says stepping away from operating leadership forced a gradual shift from being defined by a single institution to finding meaning through broader contribution.

Yet, former India Inc leaders are increasingly discovering that life after the corner office is not about retreat. Pawan Goenka, the former Managing Director of Mahindra & Mahindra, currently plays a central role in shaping India’s space-economy ambitions as the Chairman of IN-SPaCe. A seasoned industry veteran, he remains deeply engaged with manufacturing innovation and entrepreneurship as the Chairman of the SCALE Committee. C. P. Gurnani, former CEO and Managing Director of Tech Mahindra, continues to work across AI, start-ups, governance, and education through ventures such as AIONOS, board positions, and academic institutions.

Shiv Shivakumar, former Group Executive President at Aditya Birla Group and former India head of Nokia and PepsiCo, remains active as a mentor, board member, start-up advisor, and management thinker, engaging deeply with India’s evolving business landscape. Others, like Falguni Nayar, chose to build entirely new entrepreneurial journeys after corporate leadership.

Here’s a few of them and what they do now:

